

## Report of the Affirmations and Denials Committee

Appointed by Missouri Presbytery, October 2019 Stated Meeting  
Adopted June 2, 2020 Called Meeting

TEs Doriani (Chair), Dalbey, Laughlin, Maney

### Preface

In October 2019, Missouri Presbytery appointed a committee to establish a relatively short series of affirmations and denials that state the biblical fundamentals for sexual ethics, especially focusing on the question of homosexuality and identity. The moderator charged us to produce a work that is biblical, theological, and pastoral.

Human sexuality is a biblical issue since Scripture addresses it. It is theological because it demands careful reflection on Scripture. It is pastoral because the topic is controversial, in society and in the church, even among many who call themselves evangelicals. As Western culture has ever-changing views of marriage and sexuality, church members and church visitors fall under its influence. All need to hear the biblical message. While we have written affirmations and denials, we believe pastoral care begins with compassionate listening. A small percentage of the population is primarily or exclusively drawn sexually or erotically to the same sex. Sexual experimentation and seductions cause additional problems. For most, homoerotic feelings begin as an unwelcome discovery of differentness. Young people often feel horrified or ashamed. They fear discovery; many consider suicide. We must be compassionate toward our neighbors and brothers and sisters who experience strong same-sex attraction. Sadly, too often, the church has added shame and opprobrium, so that people feel silenced and marginalized. For many a “gay identity” emphasis is a way to cope with the loss of friends, family, and Christian community. We must foster compassion personally and ecclesiastically. It is for these reasons that we have found ourselves thankful for the insight of the late John Stott, who reminds us to never lose sight of the fact that there lies within the homosexual experience “a deep loneliness, the natural human hunger for mutual love, a search for identity, and a longing for completeness” (Missouri Presbytery’s *Report of the Ad Hoc Committee to Investigate Memorial Church and Revoice*, p. 74). We must foster compassion and empathy in ourselves and the church.

This document, which was adopted with a very strong majority by Missouri Presbytery at a called meeting on June 2, 2020, draws on many sources: Scripture, the Westminster Standards, and Missouri Presbytery’s studies on sexuality and homosexuality from 1994, 2017, and 2019.<sup>1</sup> While this report

---

<sup>1</sup> This report was adopted by Missouri Presbytery on June 2, 2020, but this report was completed before the release of the report by the PCA’s Ad Interim Committee on Human Sexuality, on May 28, 2020. This document therefore has no literary link to that report. This committee believes its report is consistent with the PCA Ad Interim Committee’s “Twelve Statements” on human sexuality and we commend them.

does not attempt to condense those studies, it seeks continuity with them. We tried to prepare a clear, concise biblical theology of sexuality and homosexuality. We present this document as a set of core convictions. A set of affirmations and denials is a blunt instrument and pastors must use them with care as they communicate biblical teaching on homosexuality.

*Note on our language:* After long reflection, the committee chose to use the terms “same-sex attraction” and “same-sex attracted” for the experience of sexual, erotic, or romantic desire or longing for persons of the same sex. When we use the term, we do not mean to refer to practices, behavior, or allegiances. We use it to describe the experience of sexual, erotic, or romantic desire or longing for persons of the same sex. (We do not mean to declare that the term “same-sex attraction” is “the correct term”; we simply judged that “same-sex attraction” was less likely to be misunderstood). Degrees of attraction can be variable. Same-sex attracted persons may find the same sex somewhat or very appealing. They may or may not also experience sexual, romantic, or erotic attraction to the opposite sex and may or may not enter into a complete, biblical marriage.

This committee does not advocate the use of “gay Christian” as a self-description in ordinary speech. Yet we recognize that any term one uses—gay, same-sex attracted, homosexual, homophile, queer, and others—is problematic in certain cases for certain people. Another committee may wish to use other terms. Wishing to heed Paul’s admonition to neither condemn nor despise one another over debatable matters (Rom. 14:1–12), we believe Christian liberty grants believers a degree of latitude as they describe themselves. Most words are flexible, with several meanings and nuances that vary from one place and time to another. Christians should have a certain freedom of expression for the sake of communication. For example, a pastor may not prefer to use the word “abuse” publicly because it plays into powerlessness/victimization narratives, but may yet use the term in conversation.

### **Part One:**

#### **A Concise Biblical Theology of Sexuality with Reference to Homosexuality**

##### **Marriage and Sexuality in God’s Creation (Genesis 1–2; Proverbs 5; WCF 24)**

1. We affirm that God, as Lord of creation and redemption has lovingly revealed his will for marriage and sexuality.
  2. Sexuality is God’s good gift to mankind. God designed human sexuality to bring him glory and to promote human flourishing.
  3. God wills believers to honor him with their bodies. This includes sexual intimacy in marriage (Rom. 12:1; 1 Cor. 6:19–20).
  4. God instituted marriage before the fall. When the Lord created mankind in his image, he made them male and female, blessed them with a capacity for love, and ordained monogamous marriage as the place for sexual union between a man and woman.
-

5. We affirm that the sexual union of husband and wife normally seals a marriage and expresses affection between husband and wife (Gen. 2:18–25; 24:67). We deny that sexual acts between two people of the same sex accord with God’s creational design. Such acts are not able to consummate a marriage.
6. Husband and wife should hold fast to each other, as one flesh. What God joins no one should separate (Gen. 2:23–25; Matt. 19:4–6).
7. Sexual union, within marriage, includes a procreative goal. Sexual union ordinarily leads to the blessing of children, even godly children (Gen. 1:26–28; Mal. 2:15). Loving sexual intimacy is normally a lifelong feature of marriage, health permitting.
8. We affirm that Scripture blesses singleness. Scripture affirms and blesses marriage, but does not command it. We affirm that God gives some believers the gift of singleness, freeing them to live joyful lives of obedience and service (1 Cor. 7:7; WLC 138).
9. We deny that sexuality and marriage are social constructs with infinitely malleable traits. We deny that God’s design can be disregarded at will and without cost.
10. We deny that God designed sexual union to occur outside the structure of marriage between one man and one woman.
11. We deny that sexuality exists merely for the sake of physical pleasure and personal fulfillment.

### **The Fall and Sexuality**

12. We affirm that sin has corrupted every aspect of human life, including sexuality. It has also corrupted every human institution, including marriage (WCF 6.4). Sin includes actual sin, original sin, and indwelling sin (or “corruption of nature,” WCF 6.5), all of which are the proper foci of repentance (Ps. 51:1–5; Luke 18:13).
13. Human sinfulness often manifests itself in human sexuality, including disordered desires, lust, mental sins, and physical sins. Sexual temptation arising from indwelling sin commonly assails us and often leads to enacted sexual sin (Rom. 8:22–23; James 1:14–15; WCF 6.4).
14. Same-sex attraction is a result of the fall (WCF 6.6; WSC 14, 16). It is contrary to God’s design physically and morally and is a form of indwelling sin to be lamented and mortified (Col. 3:5). We deny that same-sex attraction would have occurred apart from the fall and deny that same-sex attraction will be a feature of the new creation.
15. While heterosexual attraction often becomes sinful, through lust, God intrinsically ordered heterosexual attraction to a proper end in marriage and procreation. Same-sex attraction does not have a proper end in marriage or procreation.
16. Though homosexual sin—both in desire and action—is intrinsically disordered (Rom. 1:22–25), and, therefore, truly and properly sin (WCF 6.5), we affirm that there is no sin so small that it does not deserve damnation and no sin so great that it cannot be forgiven by Christ (WCF 15.4). We affirm the same with regard to all disordered heterosexual desire, which can be judged to be sin.

### **Redemption, Marriage, and Sexuality**

17. We affirm that the completed work of Christ atones for all of the sins of a believer. Through faith, union with Christ the Redeemer, the gifts of the Spirit, and the support of the church, believers can and should mortify all sexual sin and stir up the grace of God that is in them (WCF 13.1–3).
18. The Lord may relieve believers of sexual lust or they may long battle it as besetting, indwelling sin. Although temptations can endure, believers should hope and pray for deliverance from sexual temptation (WCF 13.3).
19. Believers can face the prospect of long, arduous obedience, even in the face of indwelling sin (WCF 9.4) and ongoing temptation (Rom. 7:14–25). Although it is possible to be tempted without sinning (1 Cor. 10:13), to willfully desire something which, if attained, would be sinful, is to participate in sin.
20. We deny that realism about struggles with sin (sexual or otherwise) necessarily constitutes making peace with sin or giving up on sanctification. Believers may or may not be released from ungodly desires in this life. The path to sanctification is not wholly predictable. In fact, realistic expectations can foster perseverance (James 1:2–4). Our Larger Catechism itself acknowledges that “in this life . . . [sanctification] is neither equal in all, nor in this life, perfect in any” (WLC 77).
21. We deny that changing from having same-sex attraction to opposite-sex attraction is the only gauge by which to judge progressive sanctification (WCF 13.2). However, God does enable believers more and more to die unto sin (WSC 35) and grow in self-control (Prov. 25:28; 2 Tim. 2:15; Gal. 5:23).
22. Correction of any sexual sin must be gentle and humble, since all are prone to sin (Gal. 6:1–4; 2 Tim. 2:24–25), and must include a call to repentance, faith, and walking in newness of life (Rom. 6:1–14).
23. We deny that the presence of homosexual temptations disqualifies a person from getting married. We also deny that the apostle Paul’s dictum, “It is better to marry than to burn [with passion]” (1 Cor. 7:9), requires that all homosexually-inclined people must get married. For some believers, homosexual desires may endure, making the prospect of entering a biblical marriage seem unlikely. However, God may grant a believer who experiences same-sex attraction love and affection for someone of the opposite sex, making a joyful, complete marriage possible. We encourage openness to this.
24. The local church should function as a spiritual family that grants acceptance, love, and community to all believers, including those with ongoing same-sex attractions. Faithful believers who experience same-sex attraction should be welcomed and encouraged to use their gifts in service in the church.

### **Marriage and Sexuality in the New Heavens and New Earth**

25. We affirm that Jesus will return to establish an everlasting kingdom and to judge all people: unbelievers will be condemned to eternal damnation and believers will be welcomed into eternal glory (WCF 33.1).

26. In glory, God's elect will be fully and forever freed from all sins and miseries (WLC 90), including those arising from sinful homosexual desires. Their sinful dispositions, temptations, and the ability to sin will end (Rev. 21:4).
27. Physical bodies will be resurrected as spiritual bodies. The elect will honor God with their bodies (1 Cor. 15:40; WCF 32). In the new creation, the church will be the perfected bride of Christ and marriage between men and women will cease (Matt. 22:30; Ephesians 5; Rev. 19:7–9; WCF 17.1).
28. While we affirm that some cultural identification will continue in the new creation, we deny that there will be any identification with any former sin in the new creation (Rev. 21:22–27).

### **Part Two: Homosexuality and Identity in Current Debate**

29. We affirm the dignity of all people as God's image bearers, regardless of the way the fall has impacted their experience of their sexuality. We deny that heterosexual people stand on higher or lower moral ground before God (Rom. 3:19–25).
30. Same-sex attraction, homosexual behaviors, or any type of gay identity would not have occurred apart from the fall.
31. We affirm that friendship is a beautiful biblical category and that “friends can become closer than brothers” (Prov. 18:24). We deny that friendships should be confused with marriages. The Bible does not recognize any relationship between two people of the same sex as a replacement for, or type of, marriage (WCF 22.7)
32. Original sin manifests itself in disease, pain, disordered desires, lust, mental sins, and physical sins. Sexual temptation arising from indwelling sin commonly assails us and often leads to actual sexual sin (Rom. 8:22–23; James 1:14–15). We deny such temptations are morally neutral.
33. Same-sex attraction is a result of the fall both as a transgression of God's law and as a consequence of mankind's estate of sin and misery (WCF 6.6; WSC 14, 16). It is contrary to God's design physically and morally and is a form of indwelling sin. Whether the presence of temptation is chosen or unchosen, one is responsible for resisting sinful desires and mortifying sin in one's life.
34. We affirm that there is a distinction between same-sex desires and temptations and the commission of sinful acts. We affirm that all sinners need Jesus's redemption, which atones for all forms of sin: inherited sin, sinful dispositions, and sinful acts.
35. We affirm that Scripture says homosexual lusts, passions, and acts are shameful (Rom. 1:24–27) and that to even speak of them amongst God's people in a trite manner is inappropriate (Eph. 5:3–5). We deny that the call to a life of repentance of same-sex sexuality consigns people with same-sex attractions to a life of morbid introspection and self-loathing.<sup>2</sup>
36. We affirm that same-sex desires belong to the category of “groaning” as we wait for the

---

<sup>2</sup> From Missouri Presbytery's *Homosexuality and the Gospel of Grace* (2017), 23.

redemption of our bodies (Rom. 8:22–25). It is common to humanity to endure all sorts of disorders of body, mind, will, emotion, and heart.

37. Because God created all people in his image and grants them common grace, we affirm that Christians should look for virtues, gifts, and blessings in the lives of all people, including those who are same-sex attracted. We deny that Scripture calls Christians to look for virtues, gifts, or blessings within any of our sinful tendencies.
38. We affirm that God has delivered his people from the domain of darkness and into the kingdom of his beloved Son, in whom we have redemption and the forgiveness of sins (Col. 1:13–14). This salvation forgives all sin, covers all shame, and engrafts us into God’s family. We deny that the promise of this gospel is any different for same-sex attracted people.
39. We affirm that it is possible to be tempted by sinful sexual desires without committing a sinful act. First Corinthians 10:13 says that God provides a “way of escape” during temptation. Although Jesus’s temptation was unique since he had no sinful nature or habits, Scripture says Jesus faced external temptation without sinning. We deny that the indwelling sinful desires that cause temptation necessarily lead to actual sin. Scripture distinguishes between desire that causes temptation and desire that gives birth to sinful acts: “But each person is tempted when he is lured and enticed by his own desire. Then desire when it has conceived gives birth to sin, and sin when it is fully grown brings forth death” (James 1:14–15; WLC 195).
40. We affirm the church community as the primary context whereby Christians grow in Christ-like character and mortify sin. Churches should lovingly use the means of grace to encourage same-sex attracted members who are sincerely striving to put to death their sin and grow in Christ-likeness.
41. We affirm that church community is the place where we learn to love one another as God, in Christ, has loved us (1 John 3:23; Rom. 15:7). To that end, the church can teach heterosexual and same-sex attracted Christians how to relate to Christian brothers and sisters of the same sex and opposite sex in a God-honoring way (1 Tim. 5:1–2).
42. We affirm that many who experienced homosexual desires will stand among God’s people on the last day (1 Cor. 6:11; Rev. 7:9–17). We deny that those with homosexual desires will be a separate tribe in heaven and deny that they will present themselves or their culture as a “queer” treasure.
43. We affirm that the essential elements of a believer’s current identity are creation in the image of God as male or female (Gen. 1:27–28), a sinful nature (Rom. 3:23), and—most importantly—union with Christ by faith (Gal. 2:20). We deny that sin will identify Christians in the new heavens and new earth.
44. We affirm that Christians can describe specific forms of sinfulness as part of their present life, so that one can say “I am the king of excuses” or “I am a workaholic” or “I am an alcoholic.” To say this is not to claim an identity, but to identify sin or sinful tendencies. Although believers do not ordinarily say “I am a male Christian” or “I am an Arab Christian,” there are occasions to do so. In dialogue, one might also say, “I am a gay Christian.” The terms “male Christian,” “Arab Christian,” and “gay Christian” are not semantically identical, since the first two label innocent aspects of identity.

45. We affirm that Scripture gives disciples latitude in self-expression. The Bible has dozens of “I am . . .” statements, including “I am a worm” (David, Ps. 22:6), “I am a Pharisee” (Paul, on trial, Acts 23:6), “I am a Levite” (Judg. 17:9), “I am a widow” (2 Sam. 14:5), “I am a sojourner” (Ps. 119:19), “I am a brother of jackals” (Job 30:29) and “I am a sinful man” (Luke 5:8). These “I am” statements include confessions of current sinfulness: “I am a man of unclean lips” (Isa. 6:5), and “Christ Jesus came into the world to save sinners, of whom I am the foremost.” We deny that these statements describe the *identity* of the speakers, but affirm that they *identify* an ongoing struggle to break with sin (1 Pet. 4:1-4).
46. In regard to language, we affirm that the command to love others and to preserve the conscience of weaker brothers compels believers in Christ to put aside their own liberties for one another (Rom. 13:8; 14:19–22). Still, Christians should study debated matters, form convictions, and may advance them as they seek peace, joy, and righteousness (Rom. 14:17–19). We deny that the “pretense of Christian liberty” ever permits a believer to “practice any sin or cherish any lust,” since that destroys the goal of Christian liberty (WCF 20.3).
47. We affirm that it is good to attend to “the rights of all the afflicted” (Prov. 31:4–5). Therefore, the church should weep with those who have been silenced or mistreated and affirm the need to treat them with justice and compassion. We recognize that it is dangerous to create an atmosphere in which individual members find it increasingly difficult to reveal themselves as Christians in need of the grace of sanctification.
48. We affirm that the legacy of the ex-gay movement and conversion therapy—however well-intended—has left many in our midst wounded, alienated, and traumatized. But we deny that the biblical sexual ethic itself is inherently violent to gay people. Rather, it is a law that gives freedom to those who, by grace, are united to Jesus our Savior.
49. We affirm that due to their own sin and the sins of others, many people who identify as gay struggle with shame over who they are. We deny that the solution for shame is to take pride in or to celebrate a gay identity; rather, the solution is found in our identity as children of God (1 John 3:1–2). We deny that anyone should take pleasure or pride in his sins or sinful inclinations.

### Conclusion

We offer these Affirmations and Denials as a guide for elders in Missouri Presbytery as they seek to care faithfully for congregants who are same-sex attracted. We do not, however, recommend that elders begin by disseminating this document directly to those seeking to live faithfully before the Lord as they contend with unwanted sexual desires. Rather, pastoral care requires that we first listen in a gentle manner, since each person’s story is unique, and then respond with discernment and love. We do hope these Affirmations and Denials will help elders offer guidance that is biblically faithful. While we do not wish to remove liberty of conscience on disputable matters, we believe these statements capture essential orthodox teachings regarding a biblical sex ethic and the particularity of homosexual experience in the lives of professed believers. We pray that this document will help elders discern wisely when considering endorsing parachurch ministries that address homosexuality and gay identity. It is our sincere hope that these Affirmations and Denials

promote clarity for Missouri Presbytery and help to promote the peace, purity, and mission of the church.

TE Dan Doriani, Committee Chair

TE Mark Dalbey

TE Ryan Laughlin

TE Sean Maney